# Waiver

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61125100.

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Teen And Up Audiences

**Archive Warnings:**
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con

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F/M, Gen

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Original Characters, Catra (She-Ra)

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by Paganaidd

Summary

In the Horde, nothing belongs to you. Not your body, not your choices. Not even your dreams.

This includes reproductive decisions. To prevent the propagation of inferior genetics, all Horde soldiers receive an implant at the beginning of puberty to prevent unplanned reproduction. To have a child, one must request a waiver.

Sara and her hybrid partner, Tom, have been denied a reproductive waiver twice, but Sara refuses to give up on the future they've imagined. She has made an appointment to request a waiver from Shadow Weaver herself.

This takes place fifteen years before the downfall of Horde Prime and twelve years before Adora finds the Sword of Protection.

Notes

This little one-shot belongs in my Tell Me Everything timeline and I am putting it in with the Stories Never Told, because is is angst heavy, but ultimately hopeful.

This was Sara and her squad when they were about eighteen. This is what life looks like to the ordinary Horde soldier.

See the end of the work for more notes

**Fifteen years before the Spire Accords**

**The Fright Zone**

For many years, the Horde had been waging war on Etheria. For almost as long, Shadow Weaver had been Hordak's Second.

Everything in the Horde was strictly regimented for maximum efficiency. Any major life decision in the Horde was subject to approval by a commanding officer. In the Horde, nothing really belonged to an individual. Not your body, not your choices, not even your dreams. Everything came with a price.

This included reproductive decisions. To prevent the propagation of inferior genetics, all Horde soldiers (all Horde citizens were also soldiers) received an implant at the beginning of puberty to prevent unplanned reproduction. To have a child, one must request a waiver. Those were under the control of Shadow Weaver herself.

Seldom was a waiver approved the first time. Most full-human couples would get approved on the second go-around. However, was the waiver denied the third time?  There was no chance.

Sara had been waiting months for this. They'd already been denied twice.  People had the right to take their case directly to Shadow Weaver. This was their last shot. Sara had made the appointment months ago. If the sorceress said no, there was nothing Sara could do. And everyone knew she hated hybrids.

But, whispers had it that the sorceress could be negotiated with if you'd pay her price. The scuttlebutt said Shadow Weaver almost always needed subjects for her experiments.

It didn’t matter what Shadow Weaver wanted. At least, that’s what Sara kept trying to tell herself. She needed this. They needed this. The hallway that led to the Black Garnet Chamber was empty. Neither Sara nor anyone she knew had ever been to the Black Garnet or Hordak’s sanctum. Normal people just did not go there. And certainly without an appointment or an invitation.

Struggling against her fear, Sara marched toward the dreaded place without looking back. There was no room for hesitation, no space to falter. Sara thought of Tom and the future they dreamed of. A child. If she wanted that, then she could not give in to fear.

Sara thought of Tom, the way his green eyes lit up when they talked about a baby. “A little one with your smarts and my stripes,” he’d said with a grin, and Sara had laughed. What would their baby be like? Would they inherit Tom’s stripes or her knack for electronics? Sometimes, on deployment, she let herself imagine the soft weight of a tiny body sleeping on her chest. A future worth fighting for.

Her squadmates didn’t know what she was doing today. They would’ve told her not to go. Even Tom had told her after their second rejection, “It’s not like we can’t raise children, Sara.” His tone had been gentle but firm, the resignation of a hybrid who had learned not to expect fairness. “They don’t care about us,” he’d said. “Just let it go.”

But Sara couldn’t let it go. She dreamed of having a child of her own. Adoption was fine for others—Amy and Markus just got sanctioned and wanted to foster soon—but it wasn’t the same.

Sara had set the appointment for when Tom and half the squad were off training, deliberately avoiding the fight she knew would come. He wouldn’t understand. This was her choice, her dream. She refused to entertain the possibility of failure. She had always wanted to be a mom. If she wasn't so good at electronics, she would have trained for the creche.

On the other hand, being good at your job was a factor.  And she had been commended in the field. All points in her favor. She was a full human, another point. Everyone knew Shadow Weaver did not care for hybrids. However, hybrid traits were recessive, so her child would probably appear fully human (unless, of course, Sara had some hybrid parentage, but she had no idea).

Afterward, Sara would never remember the conversation. What had she said? What had Shadow Weaver demanded? All she knew—clear as crystal in the seconds before everything went dark—was that she'd done it. She'd agreed. For Tom. For the future. For a child. The last thing Sara remembered clearly was Shadow Weaver's gloved hand brushing her cheek and a faint whisper: "Now, let's see how much you can take, hmm?."

After that, the world was nothing but a blinding red light and searing heat slicing into her mind. A knife twisting just behind her eyes.

Time fractured—one moment she was at Shadow Weaver's door, the next, she stood in Shadow Weaver's chamber. No, she was strapped to the table. No, she was already walking back through the hall. She heard herself scream, but it came from behind her, from a version of herself she couldn't see. Everything stuttered like a broken sim, but the pain was constant—aching, bright, and alive under her skin.

*"I wonder... are you normally this brave, or did you just forget how to be afraid?* Someone asked the question, but Sara did not know whether it was inside her head or outside.

Sara was not brave. She merely did what was necessary.

Black shadows laughed at her as they hovered and writhed around the edges of her vision, and she could not tell if they were real. How long had she been here? The shadows and red lights made it hard to think.

" What…?" She struggled to understand even as she struggled against the leather and metal that held her immobilized.

"Now, now, my dear, remember, you agreed." A cold hand stroked Sara's sweat-slicked forehead, and she cringed away as she gagged at the soft, filthy touch.

Agreed? To what? The thought slipped through her fingers like water, drowning her in the cold, suffocating dark again. Her mouth tasted like she had been vomiting, and the smell of puke and blood hung thickly in the air. Had… had she hit her head?

*What was happening?*

It did not matter. Some deep instinct told her not to ask those questions. They would open a bottomless fucking rabbit hole. One she did not want to go down.

The red light receded, and the black shadows rushed in to fill the void. Her mind struggled to stay afloat, but she felt herself sinking and falling, trapped under ice. The cold water weighed down her clothes, and she thrashed uselessly at the darkness that took her.

When she next surfaced, sick and weak, she was naked on her back. She couldn't move her arms. She felt like she had taken a beating. Was she captured?

Thin hands touched her arm, and a red mask came into view. Shadow Weaver. "Hello, my dear. Back with us?"

Not captured, then. But knowing she was not behind enemy lines did not comfort Sara. Everyone knew to avoid getting Shadow Weaver's attention.

The red light passed into her, so bright she could see the veins behind her eyelids. Like a living thing, it coiled around her spine, ribs, and gut, digging deeper with every second. She imagined it flashing through her body, leaving stark red lines like the branching of a tree.

She tried to scream, but the sound stuck in her throat, swallowed by the red electricity and Shadow Weaver's voice, soft and sickly sweet: "Don't fuss, my dear. You won't remember this."

"All right then, I suppose you've kept your end. Let's get this over with," the sorceress said as the red light receded.

*Oh.*

Hands bent Sara's legs and positioned her feet so that her knees dropped to the sides, opening her legs. Without a word of warning, the woman slid three slick fingers into her. Her body locked up as Shadow Weaver pressed deeper, probing with cold precision. Sara bit down a cry as magic sparked and rippled through her, her muscles cramping defensively. After a moment, she realized the woman was examining her reproductive organs.

"Well, everything feels fine, and your medical record indicates you haven't been running around spreading diseases." The woman scoffed. "Neither has your sanctioned partner. Surprisingly."

Deep in Sara's abdomen, something hurt. Magic sparked and rippled through her. Her muscles spasmed defensively, and sharp, shooting pain in her back made the red shadows return for a moment. Low moans came out of Sara's mouth.

"Don't fuss," Shadow Weaver scoffed. "That doesn't hurt. At least not compared to what you're signing up for." She pulled her hand out and walked somewhere behind the gurney. Sara heard a sink run. "Babies shouldn't have babies, you know."

The woman came back. The shackle that held Sara's left arm was repositioned. Palm up with her arm sticking straight on a little platform. The smell of alcohol and something wet on her bicep. A scalpel sank into her arm. A high-pitched shriek burst from her lips.

"Be quiet. It's merely a little cut. You've had far worse on the battlefield." She paused significantly, "Unless you don't want your waiver anymore?"

*Right* . The implant that prevented conception needed removal.

“N-no. Sorry. I still want it. It was just a surprise.” She gritted when it seemed like the woman actually wanted an answer.

The two stitches that closed the cut hurt less than the scalpel, but the sensation of string being dragged through a hole in her skin made Sara cringe. She consoled herself that Tom would have the paperwork to take to the medics, and his experience would not be… like this.

“There now, You've gotten what you wanted.  Aren't you grateful?” Shadow Weaver’s voice was gentle as she released her wrist from the platform.

“Y-yes, Shadow Weaver. “ Sara’s voice was rough and sore like she’d been screaming on a battlefield all day. Both wrists were bruised when Sara had struggled against steel restraints.

“You can get dressed if you like.”

Her body seemed clumsy, unfamiliar. Her hands shook as she pulled her uniform on. Time felt strange. Confused, Sara bent to tie her boots, fingers fumbling with the laces, and she couldn’t remember how long she’d been sitting there. Minutes? Hours? Her arms hung heavily, her legs shook, and the world tilted when she stood.

“By the way, I gave your fertility a little magical boost.  You’ll have a little bleeding for the next few days. Don’t bother the medics with it, or everyone will want one.  When you stop bleeding. You’ll want to act soon. You won’t have a better chance.”

Sara imagined that Shadow Weaver smiled behind her mask. It was the most chilling thing Sara had ever thought of.

“Consider it a gift.” Shadow Weaver's words slithered into her mind as the magic had slithered into her body.

“Yes, ma’am. Thank you, ma’am.” Sara said.

“You’re welcome.”

The neatly stitched and expertly dressed wound throbbed in time with Sara’s heart. That was not what made her stumble through the hall. The light in the corridor flickered, died, and flickered again, settling on a foggy yellow glow that made the shadows twistier than usual. The failing florescent bulbs hummed like the cicadas on the Arid Plains. The magic still burned under her skin, and she wanted to claw it out.

What was she doing here? Why was it hard to remember? She needed to get back to her section.  She didn’t belong here.

Something made a noise behind her; Sara whirled, grabbing for the nonexistent stun baton at her waist.

A tiny child ran across the hall on all fours. A little feline type, at the kitten stage. A fluffy brown mane fell about her radar-foil-sized ears.

The girl met Sara’s eyes and slid to a stop on the slick metal floor. She stood up to stare, with one yellow eye and one blue eye shining out of the shadows like lamps. Her blond and ginger fur was very short even with all the fluffiness, and her mane, ears, and tail were brown. The child’s sober expression was far too wise.

Tom’s face flashed in Sara’s mind, his green eyes laughing, bright and full of life. She clung to that image, forcing herself to breathe. He told her once that heterochromia was more common in magicats.

The girl’s eyes were beautiful, but Sara hoped their baby would have Tom’s eyes.

The child disappeared when Sara blinked. A hallucination. Had to be. The idea of Shadow Weaver raising children was monstrous, especially a hybrid.

She needed to get home, back to her squad. She took a step and then another.  She and Tom… they started bunking together when they were cadets. They would partner up during drills and missions, encouraging each other.

There was a song the older cadets taught, the younger, meant to help keep time on the march, but right now, she only remembered the chorus and how she and Tom would sing it on long hikes.

*One foot in front of the other foot*

*In front of the one foot in front of the other foot*

*In front of the one foot in front of the other foot*

*In front of the one foot in front of the other foot*

The song dragged her forward while the corridors twisted and writhed. Was she walking in circles? Or were the corridors changing on her?

She couldn't let anyone see her like this, couldn't explain—what would she even say? Shadow Weaver's magic still burned like snakes crawling in her belly, and she could barely breathe around it. Their bites injected magic like venom into her veins.

Apart from the heat burning her gut, she was empty inside. Hollowed out like a corpse reanimated by a Princess. Sara thought that was just a story. Had Shadow Weaver done that? Was she already dead? Had the sorceress stolen Sara's soul?

If so, then she would wander these halls, her flesh rotting, until she collapsed and the rats took her bones away.

Poor rats; she felt bad for them picking over her skinny ass bones.

The thought of the desperate little things trying to feed their babies from her bones struck her as intolerably sad. She stopped,

with one hand against the wall and the other covering her face as inexplicable moisture flooded from her eyes. Surely she was not weeping for the rats?

“Hey, Sara?” A voice. Faint at first, muffled as if heard through a pane of glass. A rat?

No. Definitely not a rat. A good voice. A trustworthy voice.

“Shit! What the fuck, Sara?” Another trusted voice cut in, sharp and urgent.

Blearily, she squinted around the black and red shadows, suddenly on guard. Could the shadows imitate the voices of her squadmates?

Her boot caught on a scrap of lint or a piece of string or - most likely- nothing at all. She pitched forward, her body too clumsy to raise her arms in time.

Hands, calloused and strong, caught her before she broke her face. These hands held her up and protected her.

Not like the hands that had… No. She would not think of that.

“Fuck, Sara. What … ?” Her squadmate and best friend, Meg, appeared in her field of vision. Meg's husband, Derrick, eased her to sit on the floor, while Meg grabbed Sara’s shoulders, “Who. Did. This?” she demanded.

What would she tell them? That she’d traded her soul for the future? That Shadow Weaver’s magic still burned inside her, reshaping her from the inside out? Claiming her. Stealing pieces of her?

“Went to see Shadow Weaver,” Sara mumbled.

The two gasped and shared a horrified glance.

“Sara,” Meg breathed, her voice cracking. Her hands shook, but she pressed them firmly against Sara’s shoulders. “What did she do to you? You’re bleeding.”

Was she? That was strange because the dressing over the incision was still clean and white. Derrick’s grip tightened around her waist, solid and grounding. Meg brushed damp hair from Sara’s forehead, her hands trembling slightly. They didn’t speak—there was no need. The looks they shared, the way they held her steady between them, said everything: *We’ve got you.*

“I got the waiver for Tom and me,” Sara whispered. She pulled the precious piece of paper from the inside pocket of her jacket. She did not remember putting it there, but she knew where it would be. She held it out to Meg.

“Oh!” Meg had never seen one before and took it in her hand to stare at it.

“Keep it safe,” Sara whispered.

“Absolutely.’ Meg slid it into her own jacket pocket. She gave her attention back to Sara. “Come on.” She brushed Sara’s bangs back. “Let’s get you cleaned up. Okay?”

Too exhausted to disagree, she let her squadmates slip their arms around her waist, pull her to her feet, and support her as she walked. Was it the magic bubbling through her or something else that made the world tilt and spin? After a few steps, Derrick gave up and just picked her up in his arms. Gratefully, Sara let her eyes slide shut.

By the time they got her to the locker room, she was barely aware of her surroundings, only opening her eyes again when they dumped her onto a bench.

Listless, Sara sat while Meg helped her undress, pulling her t-shirt over her head and helping her undo her bra. Her whole body hurt. Lifting her arms over her head was agony.

“Um… Sara?” Meg said, “Derrick’s going down to the infirmary to get something for that.”  She indicated Sara’s legs.

Sara blinked at her. Then she looked down. Dark blood soaked through the crotch of her pants and trailed down the inside leg. Mortified tears started down her face.

“Hey. Hey, it’s okay. It’s just a little blood.”  Meg helped her strip out of her bloody trousers while she cried. “Not your fault, okay?”

Meg didn’t leave her side; she stripped down, too. Grabbing one of the lightweight benches that folks used when they were injured, she put it right under the water.  “You want me to wash your hair? “ She must have seen how stiffly Sara was moving.

“Please.“  Sara wished she could wash the magic away as easily.

Meg’s sturdy fingers rubbed lather into Sara’s hair and then directed water to rinse her off. Sara leaned into the sensation of hot water cascading over her shoulders, trying to use it to drown out the memory of Shadow Weaver's cold hands.

After her hair was clean, Meg handed Sara a rough washcloth. Most of the blood was rinsed from her legs, but she stood and used the washcloth to clean up everything left behind. The red streaks swirled down the drain.

“Hey? What happened to her?” Someone asked from behind clouds of steam.

 “Shadow fucking Weaver,” Meg hissed at them, her voice cold in the hot room.

“Motherfucker.” Whoever it was backed away. “I'm so sorry. “

Other voices rippled through the room, “Nope.”

“I’m out.”

 “Shadow Weaver? Seriously?”

“Not my business.”

The shower room quickly emptied, leaving nothing but the sound of water hissing.

“Fucking cowards,” gritted Meg. “Like it’s not bad enough already.”

Even though quite a few people were there when they walked in, the locker room was empty by the time they finished showering.

Sara understood. No one wanted to stand too close to someone who had drawn Shadow Weaver’s attention. Even now, she could almost feel the old woman hovering behind her, her hair floating unnaturally. As Sara sat, pulling on the clean shirt Meg handed her, a strange heat rippled across her skin. For a moment, she thought her reflection in the locker’s dull metal door flickered, the shadows crawling under her flesh.

She shuddered and averted her eyes. Just her imagination. It had to be.

“Sara?” Meg said gently.

A low moan emerged from Sara’s throat.

“Oh, oh. It’s okay. What’s  wrong?”

Sara needed to sit, but a thick trickle of blood slowly coursed down her inner thigh. “Meg? I’m still bleeding…” she gasped.

“Is it supposed to do that?”

“I don’t know!” wailed Sara, panic rising in her throat.

Meg bit her lip, her eyes narrowing in thought. “Okay, okay. Just…” she looked around and grabbed a dry towel, folding and setting it on the bench. “Why don’t you sit there.”

Sara sat and then curled up to put her head on her knees. She could smell the blood and it made her want to puke again.

Contributing was a growing pain, low in her abdomen. She wrapped both arms across her middle.

Meg rested her arm across her back. "This okay?" she asked.

"Hey. I got your stuff." Derrick said, coming in the door. "Go ahead and throw your clothes into the laundry hamper. I stopped by our room and brought you some of Meg's clean clothes."

"Sorry," Sara choked out, taking the bundle. "I-I-I'm sorry." Another wave of shame overtook her as she realized she was crying again.

Derrick sat next to her. "Do not apologize for this," he rumbled. "Not ever. That old bitch did this."

"B-but I agreed…"

Meg was dressed, and she sat on Sara's other side. "Sara. We all know that woman plays dirty. I'm sure you never agreed to…"

"Stop. Please," squeaked Sara, as Meg's words got too close to something Sara knew should never be disturbed. "I did agree to it!" For some reason, Sara did not want them to think she had not. She wanted them to understand that she walked in there with her eyes open.

She felt the two silently communicating over her head as she pulled on her T-shirt. She picked up the bag of supplies Derrick brought. An assortment of pads and tampons, by the looks of it. He must have grabbed one each of whatever they had.

Sara stared at the supplies in the bag. They covered the theory of how to use them in health class, but she'd gotten her implant before her first period when she was twelve. She had never had a real period before. Is this what Shadow Weaver meant about giving her fertility a boost?

She looked pleadingly at Meg, who stared at the things in equal confusion. The instructions seemed written in gibberish.

“Do you…?”

Meg shook her head. “I never had to use them before.” She picked up one of the tampons and broke the seal, staring at the little plastic tube. “So I guess you shove these inside?” She shook her head some more. “There’s a diagram here, but..” Both women stared helplessly at the widening stain on the towel.

“Should she go see the medics?” Derrick whispered. “That seems like a lot of fucking blood.”

Sara shook her head. “Sh-Shadow Weaver told me not to.”

“Oh, fuck me. Seriously?” Meg hissed.

Derrick stood and walked out of the door without a word. Sara barely noticed, too focused on the blood pooling on the towel beneath her. The humiliation clogged her throat and settled in her chest. She was very glad now that the specter of Shadow Weaver had cleared the locker room.

Meg sat down on the bench beside Sara, reading the instructions for tampons while Sara stared into space.

The door banged open. “Hey, I’ve got reinforcements,” Derrick said softly. A tall orc woman stood beside him. The insignia on her communicator marked her as a Force Captain. Sara was pretty sure that she was an instructor in one of Derrick's classes.

The woman’s face softened as she glanced between Sara and the supplies in her lap. “Hey, there, soldier.” the woman said, “What’s going on?”

Silence as Sara tried to figure out what to say. After a minute, Meg spoke for her, “So, ah, Sara got a reproductive waiver, and they took her implant out, only now…” She waved at the increasingly large bloodstain on the towel while Sara resisted the urge to curl up and die. “They said not to bother the medics about this, but…”

The woman's face softened further. "Oh, yeah, okay. No problem." She picked a pad out of the bag, her voice falling Into instructor mode.

"I don't recommend tampons or cups for your first one. Those go inside of you, and they have a slight learning curve. These are easier. I can do a super quick tutorial." She picked the thing up and showed it to Sara. "Sticky side goes against your underwear," she said, pulling the bit of paper from the adhesive. "You'd be shocked at how many people get that wrong." She stuck it to the crotch of the clean underwear and handed it back to Sara. "Change them at least every three hours while you're awake," she said patiently. "If they get saturated, change them more often."

"That's all?" Sara asked. She could not meet the orc woman's eyes. She felt stupid and childish, her ears burning. "But, there's so much…"

Unbothered, the woman shrugged. "Yep, it looks more than what it actually is. However, if you find yourself bleeding through one of these in less than two hours, go see a medic." She lowered her voice. "And it's okay if you feel weepy and weird. It's pretty shitty until your hormones even out. Try not to kill your squadmates." She grinned. "You'll need them after the new recruit shows up."

"Yeah." Sara nodded her head quickly. "Thanks."

"Hey. No problem. Congrats, by the way, you three." She clapped Sara on the shoulder, and then she whispered something in Derrick's ear that Sara did not catch before she ambled out.

"It's four. Her partner's on a training mission." Derrick protested, not wanting to leave Tom out. If Sara had not felt so awful, she might have smiled at that.

"You should come back to our room," Meg said as Sara stood to pull on her underwear.

With Tom gone, Sara was alone in their room, but she did not want to impose on her squadmates any more than she had. She

opened her mouth to say no, but then she thought of the red and black shadows and knew she would have nightmares if she was alone. Instead, a tiny “Please?” tumbled from her lips.

Meg and Derrick nodded.

They both helped her stand and walked beside her to protect her from curious eyes. The room Derrick and Meg had recently been assigned as an official couple was tiny. Since none of the regular bunks would hold minotaur-types like Derrick, they had taken two mattresses and put them together on the floor and they filled up almost all of the space.

Gratefully, Sara sank to the mattress-covered floor.

Derrick said, “Let me go grab your blankets?”

Sara nodded and gave him the password for her quarters.

‘I bet you haven’t eaten,’ Meg said, settling cross-legged on the neatly made bed beside Sara.

No. Sara had not eaten today. Too nervous for breakfast, she had skipped it. The appointment had been first thing. “What time is it?” she asked.

“Nearly lights out. Here: try this.” Instead of a ration bar, Meg handed her something in a grease-stained brown paper sack, the spicy fragrance inviting in a way ration bars never were. “Lori down at the motor pool has been experimenting with something called ‘deep frying,’” she said. “She calls that a samosa. She scored a big box of spices last week. Anyway, they’re greasy as hell, but super tasty.”

Sara took a bite and tried to swallow, but her mouth was too dry. Meg pressed a flask into her hand; not water, but some rotgut they'd “found” on their last deployment. It went down easy, warming her cold insides.

“No, finish it,” Meg said when Sara tried to return it. “I can get more, and you need it.” Meg fidgeted, her eyes flicking between Sara’s face and the flask in her hand. “I’ve got some painkillers from when I wrecked my knee on that obstacle course,” she said carefully, her voice softer than usual. “You want one? They’re pretty strong, but…” She trailed off, biting her lip, clearly unsure if it was enough to make a difference.

“Yeah. That’d be great.” Sara did not know either, but it would probably help some.

Meg went to the cupboard and came back with it and a glass of water, and Sara swallowed it. Slowly, she sipped a couple of mouthfuls from the flask and nibbled on the samosa.

By the time the door chirped and opened, Sara had finished both. Derrick had returned with Sara’s blanket and pillow. He handed Sara a tiny cardboard box.

As she took it, she realized the package had the most amazing smell. Warm and sweet. Sweets were expensive on the black market. “Derrick, what?”

“This is from Huntara.” He glanced over his shoulder toward the door. “She said that where her people come from, this is traditional. The first time this…” he waved vaguely at Sara, “happens.”

“That was… so nice of her.” gasped Sara, feeling a little overwhelmed by all the care. It was one thing for her squad to look after her, but a Force Captain?

Derrick nodded. “She’s got good connections too.”

Sara opened the package, revealing a square of something almost waxy. It actually looked vaguely like a brown ration bar. But the way it smelled made her mouth water. “What is it?” She asked, dumping it out onto her hand.

“Chocolate.” Derrick smiled, “Like I said, she’s got seriously good connections.”

Sara stared at the square in her palm hesitantly. “I didn’t even know that was real,” she admitted. “I thought it was one of those stories—like how the Princesses eat gold and pearls or something.”

“Yeah, me too,” Meg said. “That smells amazing.”

Tentatively, she nibbled on a corner. Bitterness—sharp and unexpected—hit her tongue first, but then the tiny nibble melted, creamy and smooth. Like nothing she’d ever tasted. She froze, eyes wide, as the taste overtook her senses. “Oh, stars...” she whispered, voice breaking. She ate the tiny square in about three bites.

The small computer panel on the wall chirped an incoming message notification.

“Oh, wow. In fact…” Derrick said, his face lighting up with a smile as he hit the answer button. “It looks like she did get through.” The comm screen lit up.

“Hey, Derrick?” a familiar, longed-for, *impossible* voice from the comm screen said.

“Yeah, Tom? How’s it going?” Derrick asked, glancing at Sara.

Meg signed at Sara so Tom would not hear her, “ *Are you ready to talk to him?”*

Sara understood-- Meg was not sure if Sara was ready to break the news. But, she was. Between the food, the liquor and the pain killers the horror of her encounter with Shadow Weaver began to fade. Enough that she could breathe. The agony in her belly began to unknot. She felt far less like the world was ending.

She nodded.

“I’m fine,” Tom replied a little impatiently. “What’s going on? Some Force Captain called my CO and said I should call you.” His ears went back. “Is Sara…” Tom never finished that sentence.

Sara felt a surge of energy, as if she were falling back into her body. “Tom, Tom, Tom!” Sara squealed like a cadet, jumping up and trying to throw Derrick out of the way in her haste. The big man gave way with a relieved chuckle.

“Holy shit!” She had not let herself feel this before-- the elation, as well as the fear. “Tom! “ Now she was crying, the tears flooding down. “We got the waiver!”

At first, Tom’s face was blank. “The waiver?” he repeated. “We got it?”

“Yes!” Her squadmates exchanged glances as Sara’s tears broke loose, flooding down her face. “We got it.”

His green eyes widened, and then he was laughing, crying, shaking his head. “Sara, stars. You’re amazing.” His voice cracked, and his smile shone through tears.

Derrick crossed his arms, leaning against the wall. “About time something went right for us,” he muttered to Meg, who nodded with a small smile.

For a while, it was just Sara and Tom, their voices soft, promising the future they’d been fighting for.

Meg and Derrisck hovered in the background, basking in Sara and Tom’s happy news.

Later, Sara lay between her squadmates as if she were wounded in the field. As safe as anyone could be in the Fright Zone. Meg curled up behind her, her arm around Sara’s waist. Derrick put his arm across her shoulders, holding her while she cried. They did not ask questions. Questions in the Horde were dangerous.

“Meg? Derrick?”

“Yeah?”

“Thank you.”

Tom was gone until next week. After his training deployment, they were to be assigned together again. The unexplained bruises would be passed off as training. Getting regular periods after getting your implant out was just normal. The rest of it? Meg and Derrick knew better than to bring it up.

Sara focused on the waiver, on how happy Tom was, on their baby —on anything but the marks Shadow Weaver had left.

The bruises would fade, and the stitches would heal. But the terrible creeping, wriggling of the magic under her skin…. She did not think it would ever go away, but she refused to let the old witch taint her happiness at the prospect of a baby.  For now, she let herself dream of a baby with Tom’s stripes and laughing green eyes and a world where their child would never know the cost of this moment.

End Notes

I can hear the cries of, "But I thought Sara and Derrick were married."

They get married many years after this. Meg was Derrick's first wife, and Tom was Sara's first husband. Both of them were killed in action. Meg has been dead for three years and Tom for ten.

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